Accessible PDFs

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What is it for?

PDF (Portable Document Format) is used to present all kinds of documents. Ideally, all the content in a PDF should be accessible to all. Here are some ways to make it accessible:

- Enable tagging, and set the title and language, so screen readers can navigate the content
- Design with high colour contrast, legible fonts, and a single-column layout including headers and footers
- Test the final document with a screen reader and a PDF Accessibility Checker

How to support it

Avoid PDFs whenever possible. Even ‘accessible’ ones aren't natively responsive for mobile and have major downsides. Instead, challenge the PDF requirement and choose an alternative:

- Semantic HTML web pages or web apps for the most accessible experience
- Word documents, Google Docs, or slide presentations, as they offer built-in accessibility checkers and excellent screen reader support
- ePub or Markdown formats to ensure reflowable text and clean semantic structures across all devices

Useful Links

Reading PDFs with reflow and accessibility features

Adobe: Creating accessible PDFs